

Movement Disorders (Paroxysmal Dyskinesia)

What is it?

Paroxysmal dyskinesia (PD) causes **sudden episodes of abnormal movement** that come and go. Unlike seizures, your dog **stays fully aware** during an episode.

What it looks like

- Episodes start and stop suddenly, with **normal behavior in between**
- Your dog can still respond to you
- Muscle tensing, jerking, flailing legs or trembling
- Usually last **a few minutes up to 30 minutes**

Common triggers

- **Sudden movement**
- **Excitement or stress**
- **Exercise**
- **Sleep** or waking up

Breeds commonly affected

Cavalier King Charles Spaniels, **Border Terriers**, Scottish Terriers, Dalmatians, Boxers, Bichon Frise.

Diagnosis

- Neurological exam and blood tests

- **Video of the episodes** — very important
- Sometimes MRI or EEG to rule out seizures and other causes

How to help

- Avoid known triggers when possible
- Medication may help some dogs
- Diet change helps some dogs — **Border Terriers** may improve on a **gluten-free diet** (see our *Gluten-Free Diet List*)
- During an episode: keep your dog safe in a calm, padded area

Keep an episode log

Record the date, length, and what happened **before, during and after** each episode, and bring it to your appointments.

What to expect

- Many dogs live normal, happy lives with management
- Some improve with age
- With good care, this condition usually **does not shorten life**